Elevated Policy Brief



From the Periphery to the Centre:

Ensuring Substantive Women's Participation in the Ethiopian National Dialogue

Executive Summary



The success of the Ethiopian National Dialogue hinges on its ability to authentically incorporate the voices of those most affected by the nation's conflicts and governance challenges, particularly women. This brief presents a consolidated national agenda. The findings, derived from engagements with over 1,560 grassroots women and the collection of 3,800 women's agendas, reveal that core concerns, human security, accountable governance, economic justice, and foundational social rights, are the very pillars upon which lasting peace must be built.

While the Ethiopian National Dialogue Comission (ENDC) has publicly committed to inclusivity, this brief provides a critical evidence base to translate that promise into action. The challenges identified are not regional anomalies but national crises with a gendered dimension. Therefore, we argue that the integration of these gendered agendas is not a side issue but a prerequisite for the legitimacy and sustainability of the entire dialogue process. We call on the ENDC to formally partner with the Coalition and other actors and adopt its specific, measurable mechanisms, such as the 30% gender quota it has already championed, dedicated dialogue sessions on gendered issues, and the formal integration of the collected women's priority agendas, to ensure women's participation is substantive, not merely symbolic.

Introduction

The National Imperative of Gendered Inclusion

The Ethiopian National Dialogue Commission (ENDC) represents a historic opportunity to address the root causes of societal fragmentation. Its mandate to "hold an inclusive national dialogue" (ENDC, 2025) will be tested by its ability to engage populations systematically marginalized from public life. Women, who bear the disproportionate burden of conflict, displacement, and economic collapse, are one such group.

This brief synthesizes the priorities of the Women from different social status/strata: women with disabilities, civil servants, housewives, merchants, pastoralists, journalists, IDPs, security personnel, academia, farmers, and other marginalized groups. Their collective effort has gathered 3,800 women's agendas from 11 regions and 2 city administrations, providing a truly national microcosm of the challenges facing millions of Ethiopian women. By framing these issues within the ENDC's operational mandate, this document provides a clear roadmap for ensuring the national dialogue genuinely addresses the needs of over half the population, thereby strengthening its potential to achieve a credible and lasting peace.

A National Movement:

The Women's Voice Coalition

The evidence presented in this brief is not anecdotal; it is the product of a structured, nationwide mobilization effort. The Women's Voice Coalition represents a pre-existing, legitimate infrastructure for women's inclusion, demonstrating that women are not waiting to be invited but are actively organizing to shape their nation's future.

The Coalition's documented impact includes:

- **Broad Representation:** Uniting 18 diverse women's constituencies, ensuring the dialogue includes voices from every segment of society
- **Substantive Outreach:** Direct engagement with 1,295 grassroots women from five regions and one city administration, ensuring agendas are rooted in lived experience
- **Policy Influence:** Successful advocacy leading to a 30% gender quota for women in regional representation within the ENDC's own structure
- **Clear Agenda-Setting:** Formal submission of 2,700 consolidated women's agendas, distilled into 10 key priorities, to the ENDC

The Coalition is not just a stakeholder; it is a ready-made partner for the ENDC to ensure the dialogue's inclusivity and legitimacy.

Methodology

A Rigorous, Participatory Approach

The data underpinning this brief was collected through the participatory and systematic methodologies.



Participant Selection:

A purposive sampling method ensured diversity, capturing the experiences of women affected by displacement, teachers, journalists, farmers, merchants, and other key social groups.



Data Collection:

The process utilized Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) and large-scale agenda collection drives. This was complemented by Problem Tree Analysis in workshops to identify root causes and effects of key issues.



Data Analysis:

Discussions were transcribed and coded using thematic analysis. The overarching themes emerged organically from the data. The consolidation of 3,800 agendas into women's priority areas provides a powerful, quantified mandate for action.

The Evidence Base:

Women's Priorities as National Priorities

The findings reveal a set of interconnected priorities that are both locally resonant and nationally significant.

1 Human Security: The Foundation for Participation

Women's ability to engage in a national dialogue is contingent on their basic safety.

Participants highlighted:

Targeted

Over 90% of respondents reported direct harassment, restrictions on movement, and threats to their children, creating a climate of fear that precludes civic engagement



Displacement as a Gendered

Driven by conflict and unresolved disputes, displacement causes women to lose homes and land, often without legal recourse. With over 4 million IDPs in Ethiopia (IOM/ UNHCR, 2024), the majority women and children, their exclusion from dialogue processes perpetuates their vulnerability and ignores a central cause of instability



The Impact of Conflict on Youth:

Teachers reported that school closures directly lead to spikes in early marriage and exploitation of girls, creating a lost generation

This aligns with the ENDC's objective to "address historical grievances and root causes of conflict." Without safe access to dialogue venues and a specific agenda item on the rights of IDPs, particularly women, a critical segment of the population will be

2 Governance, Justice, and Meaningful Representation

Women identified systemic governance failures as the primary barrier to their rights and participation.

Corruption and Bureaucracy:

Participants universally cited corruption and bureaucratic inefficiencies as denying them access to justice, IDP registration,



Underrepresentation in Leadership:

The near-absence of women in decision-making bodies means their perspectives are absent from the structures that will implement dialogue outcomes



Ineffective Legal Protection:

Laws against GBV and child exploitation exist but are poorly enforced, especially in conflict settings



The ENDC's promise to "integrate marginalized voices" must directly confront these governance deficits.

3 Economic Justice:
A Precondition for Durable Peace

Economic marginalization fuels instability and disenf ranchisement.

Systemic Exclusion:

Women reported being systematically excluded from key economic sectors like mining and trade

Youth Unemployment:

High unemployment among educated young women was identified as a key driver of migration and risky survival strategies

The national dialogue must address the economic dimensions of the conflict. Sustainable peace requires an inclusive economic growth that explicitly includes women.

Strategic Recommendations

A Call for Specific Action

Moving beyond broad suggestions, we propose the following concrete actions:

Immediate Process-Oriented Actions:

1. **Formalize the Partnership:** Grant Timran, CoSAP, the Women's Voice Coalition, and other key actors a formal advisory role to provide ongoing technical input and monitor the ENDC's adherence to inclusivity standards.
2. **Enforce and Exceed Quotas:** Mandate and enforce a minimum of 50% women delegates and facilitators at all levels, building upon the Coalition's achieved 30% benchmark.

3. **Create Dedicated Dialogue Tracks:** Establish a formal "Thematic Committee on Gender, Human Security, and Economic Rights" with the mandate to integrate the women's **priority agendas** into the final national accord.

Substantive Agenda Items for the Dialogue:

4. **Address Land and Property Rights:** Specifically include the issue of "Women's Land and Property Rights in Disputed and Post-Conflict Areas" as a standalone agenda item.

5. **Recommend Governance Reform:** The final dialogue outcomes must include specific recommendations for legislative and policy reform to combat GBV, enforce women's inheritance rights and establish quotas for women in public leadership.

Conclusion

The women from eleven regions and two city administrations, through this brief, have presented a clear and evidence-based agenda. Their priorities are not peripheral; they are central to the national question. The ENDC now stands at a crossroads. It can choose to conduct a dialogue that replicates existing power dynamics and silences key voices, or it can seize this opportunity to model the inclusive, responsive, and just governance that Ethiopia desperately needs. By implementing these targeted recommendations, the ENDC can ensure that the national dialogue is not just a talking shop, but a genuine turning point towards a stable and equitable future for all Ethiopians.

References

CARD Ethiopia. (2024). Ethiopian National Dialogue Process – Activities Assessment Report I for Inclusion and Transparency. Addis Ababa, Ethiopia.

Central Statistical Agency of Ethiopia & The DHS Program. (2022). Ethiopia Demographic and Health Survey 2022: Key Indicators Report. Rockville, Maryland, USA: CSA and The DHS Program.

Ethiopian National Dialogue Commission (ENDC). (2025). Commission strives to engage incarcerated individuals in the national dialogue process [Press release].

International Organization for Migration (IOM) & UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR). (2024). *Internal displacement in Ethiopia: 2024 mid-year report*. Geneva, Switzerland.

Meniga, M., Ghebremichael, B., & Berhe, A. (2024). Women's empowerment through women self-help groups: An empirical evidence from Mekelle, Ethiopia. International Journal of Business and Development, 1(2), 60–72.

CONTACT US

The Consortium of Self help group Approach Promoters (CoSAP)
Lideta Sub City, Woreda 10, African Union Area
Behind National Tobacco Enterprise
Tel: +251911255456/ +251911255653/ +251980286565
Email: cosapshg@gmail.com
www.shgconsortiumeth.org
P.O.Box 26720 code 1000 Addis Ababa, Ethiopia

Disclaimer

This document has been produced independently by CoSAP. The analysis and recommendations contained herein are solely the responsibility of the authors and do not reflect the official position or endorsement of UN Women Ethiopia.